say: “Read it this way. . . .” Instead, he’d teach us that it was important to analyze our characters and think like them in ways that helped us *be that person* while we were on stage.

During a rehearsal, he’d sometimes interrupt gently and say: “What do you think your character means with that line? *Why* do you think he would say that?” Often, his questioning made you realize that you hadn’t tried hard enough to get under the skin of your character so you could understand his motivations. After a while, whenever I read a new script, I’d automatically try first to understand what made that particular human being tick by trying to put myself in his place. The process, called empathy, is not bad training for someone who goes into politics (or any other calling). By developing a knack for putting yourself in someone else’s shoes, it helps you relate better to others and perhaps understand why they think as they do, even though they come from a background much different from yours.

As I’ve grown older, perhaps there’s always been a little of that small boy inside me who found some reassurance in the applause and approval he first heard at nine or ten. But in high school, I began to lose my old feelings of insecurity; success in the school plays, in football and swimming, being the only guy on the beach with LIFE GUARD on my chest and saving seventy-seven people, being elected student body president, even the fact I could now *see*, did a lot to give me self-confidence. Still, I think there’s something about the entertainment world that attracts people who may have had youthful feelings of shyness or insecurity. After I went to Hollywood, some of the most successful people I met—a lot of actors and great comedians like Jack Benny, for example—would just sit quietly, even shyly, at a party while some of the funniest people were writers who took center stage and became the real show-offs. It made me wonder if some entertainers hadn’t gravitated to their calling because